

THE ROAD TO VINDANA

The King's Crusade — Module Five

OVERVIEW

The coalition marches the final stretch toward Vindana — with Ninian Ysolde beside it, if Sennoch Hall went well — and partway there, news catches up with them from the road they did not take. Raimon V of Oksitan, who led the other column, is dead: drowned at a ford, in armour, at the head of his own people, and his army has come apart behind him. This module delivers that news and lets the party, and the coalition around them, sit with it before Vindana's siege begins in Module 6. It is shorter and quieter than the modules before it by design. Core scenes run two and a half to three hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

PLAYING THE NEWS

This module resolves Branch Ledger entry 1 — the road choice from Module One — regardless of which variant of Module Two the table played, and it resolves it the same way in both. Raimon never reached either road. Oksitan's army had to cross the Vaskren to join the march at all, and it was at a Vaskren ford, eight days out from Aurignan, that the king of the ford-holders went in first the way he always did and did not come up. The parallel is deliberate either way: a party that took the sea road never saw the Ashgate crossing and now hears what that kind of water does, and a party that took the mountain road has already stood in cold water holding a rope and knows exactly how little it takes. Let a player make the connection without the module explaining it.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. Word on the Road	15–20 min	A rider arrives first, before the full story does.
2. The Standing Water	60–90 min	The Four Voices, again — deliberately. The module's centerpiece.
3. Vindana in Sight	30–45 min	The march ends in view of the siege to come.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Raimon's death was exactly what it appears to be: an accident of snowmelt and bad ground, not an ambush and not Vale's doing — Vale has never heard of this man and would not consider him worth the effort if he had. That plainness is the point. The coalition loses its second crown to a river or a storm, the same way real armies have, and the loss is not made more dramatic than it actually was. What the module is actually about is not the death itself but what the survivors do with it — and the old soldiers' belief that a

king of that stamp does not die but sleeps in some hill, waiting until he is needed again, is offered here as one live option among several for how the coalition receives it, not the only one.

DM Only: name him. Raimon V of Oksitan came to the throne at nineteen, spent four decades making his kingdom the arbiter of every crossing between three realms, and answered the Call within eleven days — not for the remission and not because a priest asked, but because he intended to walk the Willing Road himself before he died and could think of no other way to arrange it. His marshals, his heir, his physicians and the Concord all tried to talk him out of going in person, and his answer to all four is now quoted the length of the coalition with a good deal of affection: that he has been old for twenty years and it has not inconvenienced him yet. The king of the ford-holders, drowned in a ford, on his way to claim a road. Do not point at that. Let somebody at the table find it.

DM Only: there is a second thing this death costs and it is not grief. Oksitan wanted the Willing Road — its waystones, and the craft of cutting more of them — and Oksitan is structurally guaranteed never to have it, because nobody has ever established what the road measures and this campaign never will. The old man who wanted to walk it is dead in a river eight days from his own capital, and his officers are still marching for a thing that cannot be taken. Play them as competent, confident and entirely sincere. The tragedy only works if it is never signposted.

SCENE 1: WORD ON THE ROAD

The news arrives the way bad news on a march always does: badly, in pieces, ahead of anyone who actually knows the whole of it. A lone rider reaches the column first, half a day ahead of any official word.

Tam Ondry rides in on a horse that has clearly been ridden too hard for too long, and does not wait for permission before finding the nearest officer. "The other column," he says, and then has to stop and start again. "The king. He's not — he didn't make the crossing. Nobody's saying it plain yet, but I was there for the part before I wasn't, and I'm saying it plain. He's gone."

Tam is a Harrowmark rider, attached to the other column as a courier, and genuinely shaken rather than performing grief — let him answer the party's immediate questions plainly and incompletely, the way someone actually present for a disaster usually can. He does not have the full story; nobody does yet. That is what Scene 2 is for.

SCENE 2: THE STANDING WATER

By evening, the column has reached a Listening Water of its own — a broad, still pool fed by a spring, the kind of feature every Elduvish village seems to have one of within an hour's walk. Word has spread that this is where mourning is properly done in this land, and the coalition, uncertain of its own customs for a loss like this, borrows Elduvaine's without much discussion about whether it is entitled to.

Nobody organizes it. People simply arrive at the water's edge through the evening, in ones and twos, and say what they have to say to it. By full dark there have been enough voices that the water, when it finally answers, has a great deal to give back.

RUNNING THE SCENE

As in Module Three, read each voice below as its own boxed passage, with a pause between each. None of the four is lying. None of them is complete, and this time that incompleteness is doing real emotional work — the coalition genuinely does not agree yet on what happened or what it means, and the party is hearing that disagreement unfold in real time rather than as settled history.

A SOLDIER'S ACCOUNT

"...ford looked no worse than a dozen we'd already crossed. He went in ahead, the way he always did, wouldn't let anyone else take the lead line first. Current took the horse out from under him before anyone downstream could reach a rope to him. That's the whole of it. That's all it ever is, in the end — a bad step and cold water, no matter whose head wore the crown..."

AN OFFICER'S ACCOUNT

"...the column's command structure held, credit where it's due — his marshals had the sense to keep the line moving rather than let the army come apart on the riverbank grieving. But a coalition is a fragile thing to lose a crown out of, and I will not pretend to you that this doesn't change the arithmetic of everything that comes after it..."

WHAT THE SOLDIERS ARE ALREADY SAYING

"...my sergeant swears he's not dead, not really — swears a king like that doesn't just drown in a ditch, says he's sleeping somewhere under the water or under a hill same as the old stories tell it, and he'll wake up and come back for us when it matters most. I don't know if I believe it. I know I'd rather believe it than the alternative, and I'm not the only one..."

A PRIVATE GRIEF

"...I served his household eleven years and I don't even know what I'm meant to call this. Not treason, staying loyal to a dead man. Not foolishness either. I just wanted to say his name somewhere it would be heard, because nobody's asked me how I am, and I don't expect anybody will."

Let the table sit with this. If a player wants to speak at the water themselves, let it take their words and give them back once, faithfully, exactly as in Module Three. The scene's job is complete once all four voices have been heard; do not rush it to make room for Scene 3.

SCENE 3: VINDANA IN SIGHT

The column crests a final ridge the following day, subdued in a way it was not before Scene 2, and Vindana comes into view for the first time — walls, harbor, and the specific, particular dread of a siege that has not yet begun but is now unmistakably close.

The city sits where the coast folds around a natural harbor, walls pale even at this distance, and for a long moment nobody in the column says anything at all. Then, somewhere behind the party, someone starts walking again, and the rest of the column follows, because that is what a column does.

End the session here, on the sight of the city rather than on grief — the tone should turn forward, not linger. Hand off directly to Module 6 for the investment of Vindana.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Who Is Speaking is the Standing Water, performed rather than summarised. Nine Weeks Into a Winter is the Held Winter under Optional Content, and it is a full ninety minutes with the wolves and the troll, or forty without them.

THE PUZZLE: WHO IS SPEAKING

The Standing Water gives back the same three months in four registers and none of them are lying. The puzzle is not what happened; the puzzle is working out which voice to believe about which part, and the module should never resolve it.

Play all four. Do not label them. The players work out who is who, and then work out that the disagreement is the information.

"And on the ninth day the King crossed at the ford in the sight of his whole army, and the water took him, and there was no enemy within forty miles, and God's judgement upon it is not for us to say."

"He went in first. That is all. He always went in first, he was seventy-one and he always went in first, and the water was not even deep, and I want somebody to write down that it was not deep."

"By order of the Marshal, the crossing is closed and the column will re-form on the near bank. Companies will draw three days' ration. There will be no further movement until the succession is settled."

"He is under it. Threnn keeps what the water takes and gives it back when there is need, and he is under it sleeping, and I will thank you not to say otherwise in front of the boy."

What each voice is reliable about: the court's account has the date and the place right and the judgement wrong. The soldier has the truth and no perspective. The proclamation has the consequences and no cause. The last one has nothing right at all and is the only one that tells the party what the coalition is going to be like for the next four modules.

DM Only: the fourth voice is the one that matters and it is not a puzzle to be solved. A broken column would very much rather believe its king is kept than drowned, and a party that goes around correcting people is arguing with grief rather than with a claim. Let them try. Let it go badly. This is also, quietly, the module where the campaign teaches that the Four Voices technique does not converge on a truth, which is the whole reason it is worth using.

SET PIECE: NINE WEEKS INTO A WINTER

Bryn Aeling was planted four days into spring seven hundred years ago and generations were married under it on that basis. It has been nine weeks into a winter it was never sown in for most of a year, and it is the most legible image of the draining in the campaign.

"You cross the hedge and the temperature drops eleven degrees in a single step and the sound goes. Behind you it is a warm afternoon in the Marches. In front of you there is forty acres of birch and apple standing in nine weeks of snow that has never once thawed, and every tree in it is in full blossom, and the blossom is frozen, and it has been frozen since it opened. Nothing has fallen. Nothing can fall. It is going to be like this until the trees die, and they are dying, slowly, and in the wrong order."

What is in it. Two winter wolves working the edges, who will shadow the party for an hour before committing. A troll in the orchard-keeper's cottage, which is the reason the last two woodsmen did not come back. And the dryad, who is the actual content of the scene and is not an encounter.

Running the wolves and the troll together. Check it against your table before you commit. Two winter wolves is 1,400 XP and a troll is 1,800; at four monsters the multiplier is 2, which makes the adjusted total 6,400 and is a deadly encounter for five characters at 5th level and an extremely dangerous one for six. Either group alone is a full encounter and the module assumes they are met separately.

The dryad has been the spirit of a spring wood for three centuries and is now the spirit of a winter one, and she is neither hostile nor grateful nor able to leave. Use the Withering block in the bestiary if it comes to violence, and understand that a table which fights her has misread the scene. What she wants is for somebody to explain to her what has been done and why, and nobody in the party can, and that is the point.

DM Only: if the party asks whether killing Vale fixes her wood, the honest answer is that nobody knows and she does not expect it to. Do not have her forgive anyone. Do not have her curse anyone. She is a wood in the wrong season and the wrong season is not going to end because a war did.

NPC PROFILES

TAM ONDRY

A young Harrowmark rider, courier-attached to the other column, badly shaken by what he witnessed and not yet good at hiding it. Speech: plain, halting when the subject is the crossing itself, otherwise ordinary and even easygoing — grief has not replaced his personality, just interrupted it.

Open thread: Tam is a natural recurring minor NPC for the rest of the campaign — a DM can use him as a courier again whenever a module needs news to arrive from elsewhere, now already established as reliable and already known to the party.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

WHAT THE COALITION BELIEVES NOW

If the table wants more of the coalition's reaction before Vindana, let the party spend time in camp hearing how differently the three contingents are taking it. Oksitan is not grieving so much as calculating, badly and in public: with the king dead and the succession unsettled, every dragonborn house in that camp is quietly reckoning what its own crossing is worth now. Auberitz is genuinely sympathetic and is also already redrawing the supply tables. Harrowmark, which never met Raimon, is mostly worried about what a coalition does when a crown comes off it. Play it for texture: an argument about what kind of memorial is appropriate, and a quiet, undiscussed uptick in soldiers touching still water as they pass it. No mechanical stakes.

BRYN AELING, THE HELD WINTER

The road to Vindana runs within half a day of Bryn Aeling, the first and greatest of the Kept Season orchards, and a party that goes to look gets the campaign's most legible single image of the draining. It is written in full as this module's set piece above — Nine Weeks Into a Winter — because it is worth the whole ninety minutes if the table has them and forty if they do not. Budget it here rather than running it twice.

Two practical notes for a DM choosing between the optional scenes. This one and the ridge skirmish below do entirely different jobs, and a table that has just sat through the Standing Water is almost always better served by the wood than by a fight. And if the party has a Season-Keeper among them, or has met the Keepers at Nantcorrow, Bryn Aeling is where that background stops being flavour: the Keepers hold the map of which woods have turned and in what order, it is the best measurement of the draining outside Norvatch's ledgers, and they will give it to the right people.

A SKIRMISH ON THE RIDGE

If the table wants combat before this module ends, a Legion patrol — scouting Vindana's approaches, not expecting a coalition column this size — can be spotted and engaged on the final ridge before Scene 3. Use four Legionaries of the Sixth (Bestiary, CR 1/2) rather than the levy-grade Occupation Guard from Module Three: this close to Vindana the patrols are professionals, and the difference should be felt. They do not flee so much as break contact in good order, taking their wounded and reporting accurately, which is worse for the coalition and better for Module Six than a rout would have been.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **Branch Ledger entry 1, resolved.** Record here how the party's own road compared to the second king's — what their crossing cost against what his cost him. This closes the loop opened in Module One.
- **How the party engaged with the mourning at the Standing Water.** Whether they spoke at the water

themselves, listened only, or kept apart from it entirely — worth a line in the ledger, since it is the party's first real exposure to how this coalition grieves, and it will not be its last.

LOOT

- **A flask of Listening Water.** Drawn at the Standing Water while the mourning was going on, by whoever thought to. It holds what was said at its mouth and gives it back once, in the speaker's own voice, and then it is only water. Whatever the party chose to put in it is the point; a DM should ask, and should write down the answer.
- **Otherwise, nothing material.** This module is not about treasure any more than Module Three was. Its currency is information and tone — the Branch Ledger entry above is the actual payoff.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*